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fastatomstruct: A High-Performance Library for Structural and Dynamical Analysis of Atomic Systems

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Summary

`fastatomstruct` is a Python library, implemented primarily in Rust, designed to efficiently calculate a wide range of atomic structural and dynamical parameters. Using thread-based parallelization via Rust's `rayon` crate, the package provides fast and scalable performance for analyzing atomic configurations. In particular, many functions in this library are targeted at the structural and dynamical analysis of large liquid, supercooled-liquid, and amorphous systems. Its primary audience includes researchers in computational materials physics, materials science, and chemistry, though it is also broadly applicable to any field requiring detailed structural analysis of atomic systems.

The library provides a comprehensive suite of tools for analyzing atomic configurations, supporting the calculation of radial distribution functions, static structure factors, bond-orientational parameters, and vibrational density of states, among others. By leveraging MPI-based parallelization (`mpi4py`) alongside Rust's `rayon` crate for thread-based parallelization, `fastatomstruct` achieves high efficiency, making it particularly useful for large-scale simulations.

Statement of need

Understanding atomic structure and dynamics is fundamental in many scientific disciplines, including the study of phase transitions, the behavior of supercooled liquids, and the exploration of molecular interactions. Answering many questions in these fields requires simulations of large systems. Today, this is possible with quantum mechanical accuracy using machine-learned potentials (Friederich et al., 2021). However, efficiently calculating structural quantities from large atomic simulations can be computationally expensive. Existing tools often lack support for high-performance parallelization or the ability to integrate seamlessly with Python-based analysis workflows, such as those built around the widely used Atomic Simulation Environment (ASE) (Hjorth Larsen et al., 2017).

`fastatomstruct` addresses this gap by offering a Rust-backed implementation with efficient parallelization techniques that exploit multicore processors and thread-based parallelization. This allows researchers to investigate a wide range of atomic-scale phenomena. In materials science, the library facilitates the study of phase transitions, e.g. crystallization or melting, by tracking bond-orientational parameters and radial distribution functions, providing insights into how atomic structures evolve under changing conditions. In condensed matter physics and engineering, it enables the characterization of atomic defects, local structural distortions, and vibrational properties, aiding in the design of materials with specific desired properties. The library is particularly useful in the study of soft matter and supercooled liquids, where non-Gaussian transport behavior, mean squared displacement, and velocity autocorrelation functions help uncover the fundamental mechanisms of glassy dynamics. Furthermore, `fastatomstruct` provides tools for analyzing molecular structure through three-body correlations and other

structural parameters that go beyond the traditional two-body quantities like pair radial distribution functions.

The library's scalability makes it particularly suited for analyzing large datasets. For instance, computing the coordination numbers of a bulk structure containing half a million atoms can be completed in approximately 0.3 seconds on 96 cores (see Figure 2), demonstrating its ability to handle high-throughput simulations efficiently. Figure 1 shows a comparison of a radial distribution function calculation using `fastatomstruct` and the widely used `MDAnalysis` Python library. The calculations yield equivalent results, but `fastatomstruct` is approximately 20 times faster due to its parallelized implementation. In comparison to other commonly used packages such as `MDAnalysis` (Gowers et al., 2016; Michaud-Agrawal et al., 2011), `pymatgen` (Ong et al., 2013), or functions built into ASE, `fastatomstruct` distinguishes itself through its high-performance design and scalability. Its Rust-based core leverages advanced thread and MPI parallelization strategies to achieve substantially faster processing of large datasets, while ensuring memory and thread safety. Easy installation and a direct integration with Python workflows and established tools like ASE further streamlines its usage, avoiding the complexity often encountered with other codes.

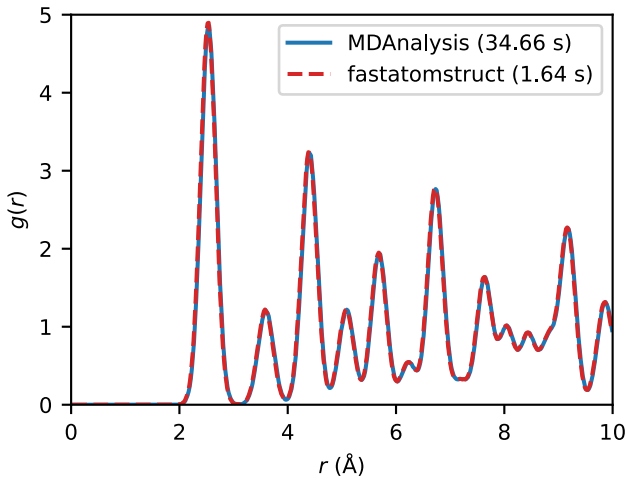

Figure 1: Comparison of radial distribution function calculation between `fastatomstruct` and `MDAnalysis` shows a 20x speedup with the parallelized implementation in `fastatomstruct`. The RDF was calculated for a Copper crystal with 108,000 atoms. Calculations were performed on an Intel Skylake node with two processors and 36 cores in total.

Features and background

The `fastatomstruct` library calculates a variety of structural quantities that provide insights into atomic arrangements. **Distances between atoms** are calculated using a linear scaling method (see Figure 2), which also allows for fast calculations of quantities like **coordination numbers**. The coordination number is the number of atoms within a defined cutoff distance r_{cut} of a reference atom. It is computed as

$$\mathrm{CN} = \sum_j \Theta(r_{\mathrm{cut}} - |\mathbf{r}_i - \mathbf{r}_j|),$$

where $\Theta(x)$ is the Heaviside step function. The **radial distribution function**, $g(r)$, quantifies the probability of finding a particle at a distance r from a reference particle. It is defined as

$$g(r) = \frac{dn_r}{4\pi\rho r^2 dr},$$

where dn_r is the number of atoms in a shell of thickness dr at a distance r from the reference atom, and ρ is the atomic number density. The **static structure factor**, $S(q)$, which is derived from the radial distribution function, describes the spatial correlations in the system and is given by

$$S(q) = 1 + 4\pi\rho \int_0^\infty r^2 \left[g(r) - 1\right] \frac{\sin(qr)}{qr} dr,$$

where ρ is again the atomic number density and q is the magnitude of the scattering vector. `fastatomstruct` further implements statistics of bond angles

$$\cos\theta_{ijk} = \frac{\mathbf{r}_{ij} \cdot \mathbf{r}_{ik}}{r_{ij} r_{ik}},$$

yielding the **bond angle distribution**.

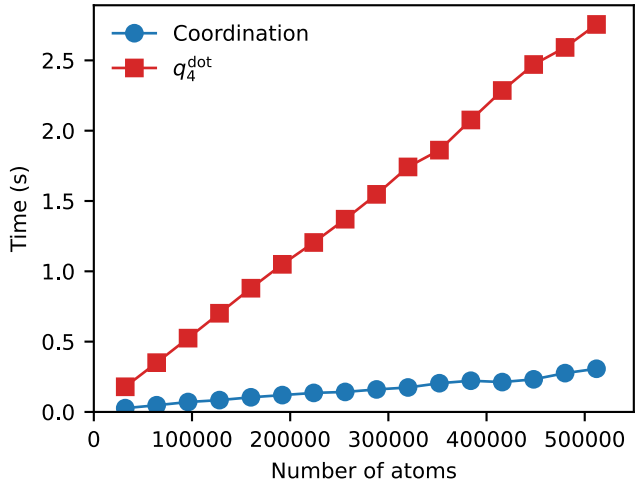

Figure 2: Linear scaling of distance calculations in `fastatomstruct` allows for efficient computation of structural quantities. The distance between atoms is calculated using spatial hashing, which divides the simulation box into cells and only considers atoms within neighboring cells. The calculations have been performed on an AMD EPYC Genoa 9654 processor with 96 cores.

`fastatomstruct` also includes implementations of a higher-order correlation function, the **three-body correlation** (TBC) (Ronneberger et al., 2016). The TBC quantifies the spatial correlations between triplets of atoms and is useful for capturing repeating geometric motifs in atomic configurations. It is defined as

$$g^{(3)}(r_1, r_2) = \frac{V}{\rho(N-1)(N-2)} \sum_{i_1, i_2, i_3} \langle \delta(r_1 - r_{i_1 i_2}) \delta(r_2 - r_{i_2 i_3}) \rangle,$$

with i_1, i_2 and i_3 distinct indices of atoms, V the unit cell volume, N the number of particles, and $\rho = V/N$ the atomic density. The average runs over time. The related **angular-limited three-body correlation** ALTBC (Bichara et al., 1993) is particularly relevant in the context of Peierls-like distortions, which here refers to alternating chains of long and short bonds in either disordered or ordered systems. The ALTBC again quantifies the spatial correlations between triplets of atoms, where the angles between pairs are constrained to lie within a specified range. It is defined as

$$g^{(3)}_{\mathrm{AL}}(r_1, r_2) = \frac{V}{\rho(N-1)(N-2)} \sum_{i_1, i_2, i_3} \langle \delta(r_1 - r_{i_1 i_2}) \delta(r_2 - r_{i_2 i_3}) \Theta(\beta - \delta) \rangle,$$

with

$$\cos\beta = \frac{\vec{r}_{i_1 i_2} \cdot \vec{r}_{i_2 i_3}}{r_{i_1 i_2} r_{i_2 i_3}}$$

the alignment angle. δ specifies the range of angles included in the calculation of the ALTBC. The **bond length ratio** allows to quantify the information contained in the ALTBC in a single number. It is defined in analogy to the ALTBC as (Holle et al., 2025)

$$\mathrm{ALBLR} = \frac{\sum\limits_{i_1,i_2,i_3} \frac{\max(r_{12},r_{23})}{\min(r_{12},r_{23})}\, \Theta(\beta-\delta)\, \bar{\Theta}(r_{12})\, \bar{\Theta}(r_{23})}{\sum\limits_{i_1,i_2,i_3} \Theta(\beta-\delta)\, \bar{\Theta}(r_{12})\, \bar{\Theta}(r_{23})}.$$

Bond-orientational parameters, originally introduced by Steinhardt et al. (Steinhardt et al., 1983), quantify the local angular symmetry around atoms. These parameters help distinguish between different phases, such as liquids and crystals. They are computed using spherical harmonics $Y_{lm}(\theta,\phi)$, with the q_l parameter given by

$$q_l = \sqrt{\frac{4\pi}{2l+1} \sum_{m=-l}^{l} |q_{lm}|^2},$$

where q_{lm} is the average spherical harmonic for neighbors around a reference particle. These parameters are widely used to characterize the structural order in liquids and glasses. The local averages are given by

$$q_{lm}(i) = \frac{1}{N_i^{\mathrm{eff}}} \sum_j f(r_{ij}) Y_{lm}(\hat{\vec{r}}_{ij}),$$

where $\hat{r}_{ij}$ denotes the normalized distance vector between atoms i and j. $f(r)$ is the radial cutoff function, which is defined as

$$f(r) = \frac{1-(r/r_{\mathrm{cut}})^{p_1}}{1-(r/r_{\mathrm{cut}})^{p_2}},$$

with the cutoff radius r_{cut} and additional parameters p_1 and p_2. For $p_1 \to \infty$ and $p_2 \to \infty$, this function becomes a sharp cutoff. N_i^{eff} is the effective coordination number

$$N_i^{\mathrm{eff}} = \sum_j f(r_{ij}).$$

Bond order correlation parameters are particularly effective at discriminating between ordered (crystalline) and disordered (amorphous) environments. "Bond order correlation" here refers to the correlation between bond orientional parameters. They are defined as (Ronneberger et al., 2016)

$$q_l^{\mathrm{dot}}(i) = \frac{1}{N_i^{\mathrm{eff}}} \sum_j f(r_{ij}) C_{ij}.$$

Here,

$$C_{ij} = \sum_{m=-l}^{l} \frac{q_{lm}(i)\, q_{lm}^*(j)}{\sqrt{\sum_m |q_{lm}(i)|^2}\, \sqrt{\sum_m |q_{lm}(j)|^2}}$$

are the bond order correlators (ten Wolde et al., 1995). The $q_{lm}(i)$ are again the local averages of spherical harmonics as given above.

To quantify the local **tetrahedral order** in atomic configurations, the library also provides the tetrahedral order parameter $q_{\mathrm{tetrahedral}}$, which is defined as (Duboué-Dijon & Laage, 2015; Lee et al., 1993)

$$q_{\mathrm{tetrahedral}} = 1 - \frac{3}{8} \sum_{i>k} \left(\frac{1}{3} + \theta_{ijk}\right)^2.$$

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Here, the sum runs over all pairs of atoms bonded to a central atom j and forming a bond angle θ_{ijk}. The parameter is calculated for a fixed number N of nearest neighbors.

For dynamical analysis, the **mean squared displacement** (MSD) is a critical quantity that tracks how far atoms move over time. It is given by

$$\mathrm{MSD}(t) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\langle|\mathbf{r}_i(t) - \mathbf{r}_i(0)|^2\rangle,$$

where $\mathbf{r}_i(t)$ is the position of atom i at time t, and the average is taken over all atoms. The MSD provides insights into diffusive behavior in materials. `fastatomstruct` uses the very efficient `tidynamics` Python library (Buyl, 2018) to calculate the time-averaged MSD. The non-averaged MSD is implemented in `fastatomstruct` itself.

The **non-Gaussian parameter** (NGP) measures deviations from Gaussian diffusion and is defined as

$$\alpha_2(t) = \frac{\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\langle|\mathbf{r}_i(t) - \mathbf{r}_i(0)|^4\rangle}{\left(\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\langle|\mathbf{r}_i(t) - \mathbf{r}_i(0)|^2\rangle\right)^2} - 1.$$

This parameter is particularly useful for identifying heterogeneities in atomic motion.

The (coherent) **intermediate scattering function** describes the decay of the density fluctuations in the system. It is given by the Fourier-transform of the autocorrelation function of the particle density,

$$F(\boldsymbol{q}, t) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i,j}^{N}\left\langle \exp\left[i\boldsymbol{q}\cdot\left(\boldsymbol{r}_i(t) - \boldsymbol{r}_j(0)\right)\right]\right\rangle.$$

Note that $S(\boldsymbol{q}) = F(\boldsymbol{q}, 0)$ for the static structure factor. The *incoherent* or *self*-part of the intermediate scattering function,

$$F_{\mathrm{incoh}}(\boldsymbol{q}, t) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i}^{N}\left\langle \exp\left[i\boldsymbol{q}\cdot\left(\boldsymbol{r}_i(t) - \boldsymbol{r}_i(0)\right)\right]\right\rangle,$$

captures only single-particle (diffusive) motion.

The **overlap parameter** (Lačević et al., 2003)

$$Q(t) = \sum_{i,j=1}^{N} w(|\mathbf{r}_i(0) - \mathbf{r}_j(t)|)$$

is a simple but powerful tool to quantify the overlap of a configuration at time t with the reference configuration at $t = 0$. It gives the number of particles that either remained within their environment of size a, or were replaced by another particle. The extent of this region is introduced via the function $w(x)$, which is equal to one for $x < a$, and zero otherwise. The so-called self part is given by

$$Q_{\mathrm{s}}(t) = \sum_{i=1}^{N} w(|\mathbf{r}_i(0) - \mathbf{r}_i(t)|).$$

The corresponding distinct part ($i \neq j$) is usually small and only visible on very long timescales. We can now also define a **four-point susceptibility** that measures variability of Q,

$$\chi_4(t) = \frac{\beta V}{N^2}\langle Q^2(t)\rangle - \langle Q(t)\rangle^2.$$

As explained by Lačević *et al.* (Lačević et al., 2003), this quantity can be related to the size of dynamically correlated regions. We can split it into three different contributions, the self part

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$\chi_{\mathrm{ss}}(t)$, the distinct part $\chi_{\mathrm{dd}}(t)$, and the cross part $\chi_{\mathrm{sd}}(t)$, which are defined as

$$\begin{aligned}
\chi_{\mathrm{ss}}(t) &= \frac{\beta V}{N^2}\langle Q_{\mathrm{s}}^2(t)\rangle - \langle Q_{\mathrm{s}}(t)\rangle^2, \\
\chi_{\mathrm{dd}}(t) &= \frac{\beta V}{N^2}\langle Q_{\mathrm{d}}^2(t)\rangle - \langle Q_{\mathrm{d}}(t)\rangle^2, \text{and} \\
\chi_{\mathrm{sd}}(t) &= \frac{\beta V}{N^2}\langle Q_{\mathrm{s}}(t)Q_{\mathrm{d}}(t)\rangle - \langle Q_{\mathrm{s}}(t)\rangle\langle Q_{\mathrm{d}}(t)\rangle.
\end{aligned}$$

The distinct part and cross part almost completely cancel each other and thus only contribute minor corrections to the full four-point susceptibility.

The **velocity autocorrelation function** (VACF) describes how the velocity of an atom is correlated with itself over time and is given by

$$C_v(t) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\langle \mathbf{v}_i(0)\cdot\mathbf{v}_i(t)\rangle,$$

where $\mathbf{v}_i(t)$ is the velocity of atom i at time t. VACFs provide information about vibrational modes. The **vibrational density of states** (VDOS) can be derived either from a direct FFT of atomic velocities, or from the Fourier transform of the VACF. It gives the distribution of vibrational frequencies in a material. `fastatomstruct` closely follows the implementation of the `pwtools` Python library (Schmerler, 2025) to calculate the VDOS, but offers a direct interface with the Atomic Simulation Environment (ASE).

The **viscosity** can be calculated directly from the stress-stress autocorrelation function as (Cui et al., 1996)

$$\eta = \frac{V}{k_{\mathrm{B}}T}\lim_{T\to\infty}\int_0^T \left\langle \sigma_{xy}(t')\,\sigma_{xy}(0)\right\rangle \mathrm{d}t'.$$

`fastatomstruct` supports the calculation of this autocorrelation and viscosity from molecular dynamics simulations.

Finally, we would like to note that parallelization is a core strength of the library. Thread-based parallelization using Rust's `rayon` library ensures efficient use of multicore processors, while image-based parallelization with MPI enables scalability to datasets with many different snapshots. Figure 3 shows the scaling behavior of different functions implemented in `fastatomstruct`. The library's compatibility with ASE and other Python-based tools further simplifies integration and usability for researchers. The Rust implementation has several advantages over more traditional approaches like combining Python with C or Fortran (Perkel, 2020). By design, Rust guarantees both memory and thread safety, which excludes entire classes of bugs that are common in other languages. In particular, Rust's ownership concept excludes race conditions, which makes it straightforward to write parallel code that is both fast and correct. The Rust compiler provides extensive static analysis, which can catch many bugs at compile time. As a result, `fastatomstruct` is a very robust and reliable library for structural and dynamical analysis of atomic systems. We hope that our approach using a rather non-traditional language for scientific computing can inspire other works to adopt Rust for high-performance computing tasks. Besides the advantages over languages like C/C++ or Fortran mentioned above, Rust also offers modern tooling and easy integration with Python through the `Py03` crate, and it can be interfaced with existing C/C++ or Fortran code. Increasing usage of Rust should also improve the overall quality of scientific software by finding and eliminating common bugs very early in the development process.

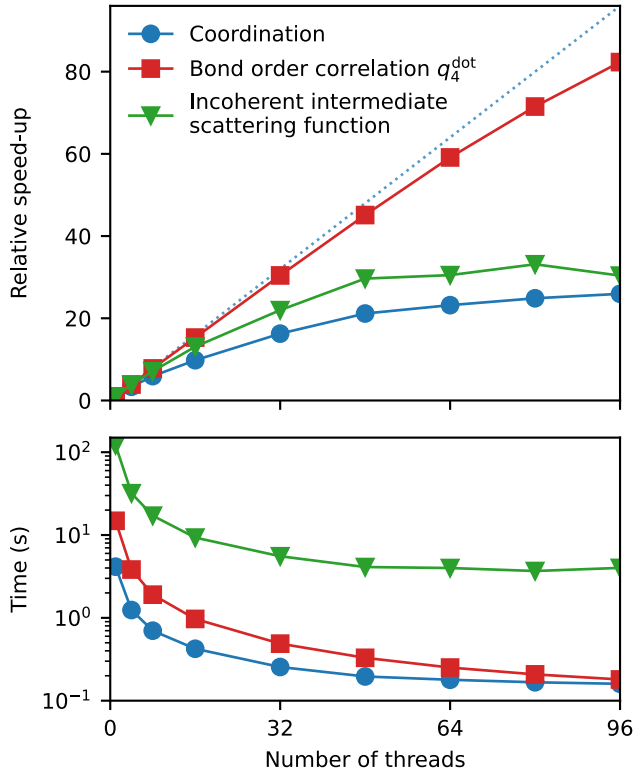

Figure 3: Scaling behavior of exemplary calculations with `fastatomstruct`. Relative speed-ups compared to a single thread (top) and total calculation times (bottom) are shown for calculations of coordination numbers, bond order correlation, and the incoherent intermediate scattering function. Tests have been performed on an AMD EPYC Genoa 9654 processor with 96 cores. A system with 32,000 atoms was used for the calculation of the bond order correlation parameter q_4^{dot}. 256,000 atoms were used for coordination number calculations. The incoherent intermediate scattering function was calculated for 600 snapshots from a molecular dynamics simulation with 32,000 atoms. Note that scalability for large thread counts is mainly limited by the conversion of ASE objects to the internal representation of atomic structures in `fastatomstruct`.

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Applications in Research

The `fastatomstruct` package enables the study of a wide range of structural and dynamical phenomena. For instance, researchers can analyze phase transitions in amorphous materials by calculating bond-orientational parameters, which provide insights into changes in local atomic order. The library is particularly suited for studying the dynamics of supercooled liquids and glasses. This has been exploited in recent studies of liquid, supercooled-liquid and glassy antimony (Holle et al., 2025).

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